

PTI

MUSLIM NARI SHAKTI
Muslim women after casting their vote in Kairana, UP, Apr. 19

ITS SWEEPING WINS IN 2014 & 2019 MAY HAVE MADE THE MUSLIM VOTE SEEM REDUNDANT, BUT BJP'S RETURN THIS TIME HINGES ON MUSLIM-HEAVY UP, BIHAR, BENGAL AND MAHARASHTRA

Why Muslims Matter

India has the world's third-highest number of Muslims—it is the country's largest minority, forming 14 per cent of its population. In electoral terms, Muslims comprise at least 20 per cent of the population in 86 of India's 543 Lok Sabha constituencies (see *The State of Muslims*). In 16 such seats, that share in the population is above 50 per cent. However, the influence of the Muslim voters remains geographically limited as these 86 seats are spread across 12 states and three Union territories (UTs), 71 in five states and one UT—UP, West Bengal, Kerala, Bihar, Assam and Jammu and Kashmir.

Political parties often target Muslim voters under the assumption that they vote en bloc across the country for a particular agenda or party. But electoral data has proved the idea of a unified Muslim vote bank as largely a myth. The reports of the 2006 Sachar Committee and the 2007 Ranganath Misra Commission revealed that Muslims still lag behind the average benchmark in almost all socio-economic and political indicators. Given their desperate living conditions, most Muslim voters, experts say, are driven by constituency-level politics. Besides, like the Hindus, the Muslim identity, too, is highly fragmented, changing with religious denomination, language, caste and class. "Muslims have now understood that the real empowerment is through education, employment and development," says Badruddin Ajmal, chief of the All India United Democratic Front (AIUDF), a Muslim-dominated party in Assam, a state with 34 per cent Muslim population. "So, these factors will determine the voting patterns of the Muslims." BJP leader Shazia Ilmi concurs as she says that the community has moved beyond the singular agenda of deciding the electoral outcome.

The best example of past fragmented voting by Muslims are the 23 seats in UP that have a Muslim population of 20 per cent at least, with over 40 per cent in seven of them. In 2009, seven of these seats were with the SP, another seven with the Congress, four with the BSP, three with the BJP and two with the Rashtriya Lok Dal (RLD). In 2014, when Hindu votes consolidated behind the BJP, the fragmented Muslim votes ensured the BJP won in 22 of these seats, including Rampur and Sambhal, where the Muslim population is over 50 per cent. In 2019, when the SP and BSP contested as alliance partners, it did not result in any significant unification of Muslim votes—the BJP lost only seven of the 23 seats. In the 2017 assembly election in the state, 65 per cent of the Muslims backed the Congress-SP alliance, but 19 per cent still voted for the BSP and six per cent even for the BJP, according to the Lokniti-CSDS data. In Assam, where over 60 per cent of the Assamese-speaking Muslims voted for the Congress in the past two elections, while the loyalty of the Bengali-speaking Muslims, at just over 35 per cent, has remained equally divided between the Congress and the AIUDF. In fact, in most Muslim-dominated states such as UP, Bihar, West Bengal and Assam, Muslim votes have remained split between the Congress and regional parties. Not surprisingly, in 2019, the BJP, despite low support from the community, won 36 of the 86 Muslim-dominated seats, two less than in 2014.

If one looks at national vote shares, the Congress and BJP have fielded around 400 candidates in the past three elections—2009, 2014 and 2019—yet the combined Muslim vote share of the two parties has hovered between 42 per cent and 47 per cent, with that for the BJP swinging between 4 per cent and 9 per cent. This is an indication that the majority of the Muslim votes have remained divided among regional parties.

But 2024 could be a watershed